

Understanding School Avoidance

The research behind BRIDGE's 'Behaviour Has a Reason': why avoidance so often shows up at school, and what the evidence says helps.

A Shift in Language

Researchers and educators have largely moved away from the term “school refusal” toward “emotionally based school avoidance” (EBSA), because the newer term centres a young person’s unmet emotional needs rather than framing non-attendance as a deliberate choice (Halligan & Cryer, 2022; Thambirajah et al., 2008). This distinction matters for how adults respond: a young person avoiding school because of genuine distress needs a very different response than one who is truant while parents believe they are at school.

How Common Is It

Estimates vary by region and methodology, but EBSA is thought to affect somewhere between 1 and 5 per cent of school-aged children in both the UK and Australia, with rates trending higher since the pandemic and in the secondary school years (Elliott, 1999; Elliott & Place, 2019; Sewell, 2008; Gulliford & Miller, 2015). In late 2022, an Australian Senate inquiry into school refusal was referred to the Education and Employment References Committee, a sign of how significant the issue has become nationally, not just clinically.

Why It Happens: Four Functions, Not One Cause

The most widely used framework for understanding why a young person avoids school comes from Kearney and Silverman’s functional model, which identifies four distinct reasons avoidance can be maintained: avoiding situations that provoke anxiety or low mood, escaping specific social or evaluative pressures (like being called on in class, or a test), seeking attention from a parent or caregiver, and pursuing something more rewarding outside of school (Kearney & Silverman, 1990; Kearney & Albano, 2004). The first two are maintained by negative reinforcement (the relief of escaping discomfort), while the second two are maintained by positive reinforcement.

Why this matters for BRIDGE

Escape/avoidance, attention, and access/tangible are three of BRIDGE’s own five function categories in step B. They were built independently, but they land squarely inside decades of published research on exactly this behaviour. School avoidance is one of the clearest real-world examples of “behaviour has a reason” in action.

The Cycle That Keeps It Going

Avoidance works in the short term. Staying home removes the anxiety-provoking stimulus immediately, and that relief is exactly what reinforces the avoidance and makes it a hard pattern to break. Over time, though, missed school tends to increase the very anxiety it was meant to relieve: the young person falls further behind academically and socially, which makes returning feel even more daunting (Effective School Solutions, 2025). This self-reinforcing loop, sometimes described as a vicious cycle, is well documented in the broader anxiety literature, not just in school-specific research, and is part of why early identification and response matter so much.

Who’s Most Affected

Neurodivergent students are substantially over-represented. Australian and international research estimates autistic students are three to four times more likely to experience school avoidance than their neurotypical peers, with school-avoidance-type absence accounting for as much as 43 to 57 per cent of all absences among autistic students (360info, 2024; Think Psychologists, 2025). Students with ADHD, dyslexia, sensory processing differences, and other neurodevelopmental profiles are also at elevated risk, though Australian-specific data on these groups remains comparatively limited (360info, 2024).

What the Evidence Says Helps

Cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) is the most consistently evidence-supported intervention, with studies reporting roughly 70 per cent of children showing meaningful improvement (Effective School Solutions, 2025). But the research is consistent on one point: no single intervention delivered in isolation works as well as a multimodal approach that brings together the young person, their family, and the school. Gradual, structured exposure back into the school environment, rather than an all-or-

nothing return, is a recurring feature of effective programs, alongside family-focused work that addresses how well-meaning parental accommodation can unintentionally reinforce avoidance.

How This Shapes BRIDGE

The evidence base above isn't incidental to BRIDGE. It's the reason each step is shaped the way it is:

	BRIDGE step	How it reflects the evidence
B	Behaviour Has a Reason	Functional assessment before intervention, consistent with Kearney's four-function model.
R	Record the Pattern	Tracking when and where avoidance shows up mirrors the antecedent-based assessment used in clinical practice.
I	Identify One Shared Goal	Reflects the evidence that family-school-clinical alignment on a single target outperforms fragmented goals.
D	Design Matching Strategies	Gradual, consistent exposure across home and school reflects the multimodal evidence base directly.
G	Give Consistent Language	Reduces the mixed messages that can unintentionally reinforce avoidance.
E	Evaluate & Adjust Together	Mirrors the iterative, data-informed nature of effective clinical programs.

A Note on Scope

Persistent school avoidance, especially where a young person has been out of school for an extended period, often needs input beyond what a coaching relationship alone can provide, including a GP, psychologist, paediatrician, or psychiatrist (Psych4Schools, 2025). BRIDGE is designed to give families and educators a consistent, practical starting framework; it is not a replacement for clinical assessment or treatment where that is needed.

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